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Greg Caputo

Drummer Greg Caputo places great emphasis on being versatile in today's music scene. He decided on a life in music at an early age and counts both his father and drummer Joe Morello as major influences on his career. He has performed with Sammy Davis Jr., Claude Williams, Benny Waters, The Benny Goodman Sextet, The Artie Shaw Big Band, and in numerous show bands. Greg frequently presents clinics for percussion students and will tour Europe in the summer of '98 with a jazz group from the University of Massachusetts.

Greg was interviewed in Clinton, New York on March 14, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming on the Hamilton College campus for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and I am very pleased to have Greg Caputo, drummer, with me as my guest.

GC: Thank you for having me.

MR: You're welcome. As I'm looking at your list of people you've played with, it goes from Joan Rivers to Cab Calloway, to Darius Brubeck, and I'm thinking of the term "journeyman drummer." Do you call yourself a journeyman drummer?

GC: I call myself versatile. I call myself versatile. Yes. And I play any style and thus, I like to, it helps with my discipline, playing the shows, and I use that discipline in my jazz playing. So I'm a versatile player, I play all styles, and I enjoy that, it keeps me fresh, and I kind of steal from each one of those styles and institute it in my jazz playing.

MR: Discipline in jazz playing. That's an interesting concept. How do you pass that idea on to students, that there has to be discipline in a music that supposedly is all about freedom?

GC: Well it's a structured music. It's not totally free. I mean I just can't go in and play anything I want, I listen to the other people, and I have to have discipline to be able to respond, call and respond, and feel. It's discipline, make no mistake about it, that all of the great jazz masters have discipline in their playing. To convey that to students, to communicate that, it's not easy. Usually they have to get their feet wet and they'll come back to me and say I'm in trouble. I need this discipline. And then I can start a foundation and give them the rudiments and the discipline of reading, and how that gives them self control in their playing.

MR: Is it hard to convey to a young up and coming student who's really feeling that I've got this stuff down, not only the discipline but also the realities that some day they may be required to do this kind of playing, and you better be able to do it? Do they tend to not believe you until they get out and see that?

GC: Every student is different first of all, I don't have one method. I sit down and I talk with a

with them. I have many older students that come to me, and they come to me with situations they've been in, it might be a technique that they need to polish, it might be reading, or it might be just how to handle themselves with other musicians. And I cover all that. Some of the younger students, right now they're involved in a school show. They might come to me with just a piece of music they want me to play for them, which I won't do, I'll give them key parts of it, and eventually I'll let them play but I won't play it for them. I adjust my teaching method to every student, and all of them can play as a result of it. I'm proud of them and they all keep in contact with me which is gratifying.

MR: Have some of them gone on to be really full time players?

GC: Some of them have, in other areas of the country. They do book shows, one went on to do "A Chorus Line," and he traveled all over the country, and one of them is a studio musician in L.A., and a few of them have made livelihoods out of it, in the country/western field. And I had a few females that went on to play metal music and were quite successful. And they keep in contact with me, particularly at Christmas time, you get all these Christmas cards, again gratifying.

MR: Well we coincidentally just found out that we were both born in 1950. And it was an okay year to be born I guess. What do you remember, as a child, the first kind of music from either records or radio that kind of seeped into your consciousness?

GC: Before I was born my father was a professional musician. And he was friends with Phil Woods, the famous jazz saxophone player, Sal Salvador, a great jazz guitarist, and Joe Morello, a phenomenal drummer. And he used to always be playing their records or the records of the jazz masters all the time. So I had to be exposed to it before I was born. So I feel that that was a big influence.

MR: Yeah your fate was kind of cast early, wasn't it?

GC: Yes it was.

MR: So there definitely was jazz in your house.

GC: All the time, yes.

MR: Did you — what did your father play?

GC: My father was a keyboard player.

MR: Did he give you instruction or tips?

GC: Actually he tried to keep me out of the business. As we know it's not an easy profession, it can be pretty brutal, and he didn't want me exposed to that, so he tried to keep me out of it. And it didn't work of course, I didn't listen. My father was legally blind and my mom had to drive him to all of the jobs, so I got to hear like the first couple tunes and the last couple tunes, and I really took an interest in the drums, because he played a lot of Joe Morello's albums and I was just drawn to the drums. And eventually I was able to borrow

MR: And your father's going no, no.

GC: Absolutely no.

MR: What did he envision for you? Did you have other talents that he thought that you could pursue? Or interests?

GC: I had math aptitude to I guess banker, insurance, salesman, something like that. But he just didn't want me in the music field.

MR: Something that you could support him in his old age perhaps. What about the rock & roll of the later 50s, early 60s? Did it have any effect on you at all?

GC: Not in my household, because it really wasn't music that was allowed. Now I heard it when I was out, but wasn't impressed by it.

MR: You mean you weren't impressed by the drum solo in "Wipe Out?"

GC: No. No, I was not impressed by that. It didn't hold a candle to "Take Five."

MR: Okay. Well you had one more beat per measure, come on. Tell me about "Take Five." Is there something particular about that tune?

GC: That tune, it's special to me because it kind of really drew me to the drums, and the extra beat, because my father did point out, when it came out, and I listened to that drum solo, and still do, over and over again. It's just a work of a genius. The time and space and just the cool jazz feel to it. And really that tune brought like commercial jazz to the front. It did a lot. I don't think people really realize. People were — it was on the radio, "Take Five," the song, a jazz tune, in five-four yet, was regularly heard on the radio.

MR: On AM.

GC: On AM. Something that just wasn't done before or has done since really.

MR: Even the fact that it started with the drums you know, and even the sound of the drums. Everything about that tune just seemed to be so perfect to make an inroad for the music perhaps. Didn't they cut out the drum solo on some of the recordings, that they wanted to shrink, they wanted to have a shorter version I think?

GC: I believe there is three recordings of it. I believe there's one without the drum solo and one with the short version, and one with a long version. And I think the shorter one they used to play on the radio quite a bit, but when I hear it now, it's the full version.

MR: Well you've had a relationship with Joe Morello over the years. Can you tell me about him a little bit?

GC: Well he was around the house quite a bit when I was growing up, because he was friends with my dad. And when he was traveling with the quartet he used to come home to his family and inevitably stop by and see my father, and talk about the road and what was going on and give the latest album to my dad, autographed. And I can remember when he came up with "Rondo a la Turk." That was something else that — what do you think of

on and they would put one another on constantly, so I was exposed to him. And when he came through, he would ask me, "Well how's your left hand?" You know, how's this going, how's this going, and listen to me a little bit, and forget about it. And he was a task master. And he wanted the student that really wanted it. You couldn't just have an interest in music, you have to want it, and I wanted it, and I kept coming back to it. And then I asked him, "Well listen to this now." And eventually I went down to New Jersey and took some lessons with him. But a big influence, one of my favorite drummers of all time. A master, a legend.

MR: And he had a start with — well Marian McPartland was kind a of big part of his initial career, wasn't it?

GC: Yes. They had to — my father got Joe Morello's his first job in the Grand Ole Opry.

MR: Say it again?

GC: My father got Joe Morello his first job he played, in the Grand Ole Opry.

MR: No kidding.

GC: Yes, which was country music, a little known fact. And you know then people started to listen to this guy, wow, he's quite a drummer. And then he came home and they literally had to force Joe Morello to go to New York City. He was playing at the Club 21 in Springfield with Whitey Bernard on Hammond organ. And he took the place of Joe Rasch, who was an area drummer. And Joe Rasch went into the service. Well Joe took his job and played with Whitey Bernard. Joe Rasch came back and as was law, you had to give back the job that you left. So Joe Morello had to vacate his position.

MR: The military thing you mean?

GC: Military, yeah.

MR: That a returning serviceman was entitled to his job if he wanted it.

GC: Exactly. So Joe Rasch wanted his job back and Joe Morello was out and with no job they brought him down to New York City, and Marian McPartland listened to him, and the rest is history.

MR: It was at the Hickory House.

GC: Yes, exactly.

MR: Did the Brubeck thing, didn't Brubeck hang out down there a little bit and hear him?

GC: Yes, exactly.

MR: I wonder what made Joe Morello so seemingly perfect for the odd time signature thing?

GC: Joe was doing that back in Springfield because he was bored with playing in four-four time. So he says well let me do one-two-three-four-one. They he started expanding it, and let me do one-two-three-one-two, and how about one-two, one-two-three. So he was very, he practiced all the time. I can remember his sister telling me that after a job he

on the couch with the sticks out on the floor and something, and to this day, he practices three, four hours a day.

MR: So he must have been like a catalyst for Brubeck's writing in those kind of oddball time signatures because he was so good at it.

GC: They heard him warming up, playing a five-four rudiment. And it caught the ear of Dave Brubeck. And he says well what is that? And he says well it's a para diddle diddle with a para diddle, it comes out to five-four time. A basic drummer's rudiment. And he asked Paul Desmond to write something. He says well why don't we write something in five-four time, and thus, "Take Five."

MR: Umm. That was a fortuitous little encounter. Didn't they do that thing in seven also? "Unsquare Dance."

GC: "Unsquare [Square] Dance," with the ticking sound which was done on the edge of a stage. They wanted a different sound and Joe was doing it on the rims, and they were experimenting. There was no wood block, Joe didn't have a wood block, so Brubeck said, "Well what about the edge of the stage? It's maple, let's try that." So Joe went down and it's on the record, it's the edge of the stage.

MR: I like that recording. I think the liner notes say you can hear him chuckle at the end of it.

GC: Yes you can. That was a first take.

MR: When did you get your first drumset?

GC: Well my father didn't want me in the business, so like I said I had gotten a pair of drum sticks from a drummer, and then I got a snare drum from another drummer, oh wow. I was on my way. And eventually my father got into a pickle once and needed a drummer. His drummer didn't show up. So he made the phone call to my mother, and I played the job.

MR: That's great. That must have been difficult for him.

GC: Yeah, it was difficult, but then he realized that he's a goner. That's it. And I played the job pretty well because he was really amazed at what I had picked up from the records, and just observing what was going on from other drummers. There were a few things, like the Latin I needed to brush up on, technique certainly, and reading I couldn't read at that point. But he eventually did buy me a drumset. It was a jelly bean kit. It was all different colors because every time I finished a book, he would buy me another drum. So we could never find anything that matched, so I had a jelly bean kit. Then he didn't like that, because he was a real professional, so we traded that in and we got an entry level kit.

MR: He used that as a little initiative to keep your studies up?

GC: Yes.

MR: That's interesting.

MR: Gosh. Did you have to read a bigger book to get a bass drum? Well that's great. So your first real playing experience was with your father. Then you started branching out and playing with local people?

GC: Yes. Well he was a task master, and he taught me well. To be taught from another musician is quite interesting. To be taught from another drummer is one aspect and certainly a requirement. But to have a keyboard player tell you what a keyboard wants to hear out of you, definitely added something to my playing. And I use that. To this day I'll ask other instruments what they like to hear out of me at different times during a tune. So to answer your question, my father was a well known area musician, and sooner or later other bands got stuck for a drummer, and I was asked. And I was playing out quite a bit because I was able to — I knew a lot of the commercial tunes and I did a lot of the country club work.

MR: And the country club work requires a specific kind of thing, like how old were you when you started doing that?

GC: I was about 14.

MR: So if the leader of the band called a tune and said to you, "Businessman's bounce," you knew what that meant?

GC: Exactly. Because I was exposed to it in my household before I was born.

MR: That must have been pretty neat for the musicians — hey, wow, the kid knows what it is.

GC: Yeah it was. It was, of course it got me into trouble eventually because my father was a well known musician, and I got pushed along too fast. I knew these things, and eventually someone called up for a show, and I took it. And I thought I could cut it because I could read some of the exercises, and I couldn't. And it tainted me for a while. The next day I made an appointment with a drum teacher who could read and was experienced in shows, and within two years I could play a show fluently.

MR: That's a big responsibility in a pit band, isn't it?

GC: Very large. Everybody can be making clams, but if the drummer doesn't make it, it train wrecks. I feel a big responsibility when I take a show. Recently I did a show where I ran into a situation after being in this business many years, where I subbed for a drummer and I could read the part fine, but he had the drumset screwed down to the stage in the manner that he played it. And it was next to impossible for me to play. It was a big responsibility and people were asking me, are you okay? But it was just impossible to negotiate.

MR: How do you explain it?

GC: I subbed in "A Chorus Line" in New York City, and the drummer is in literally a plexiglass box, totally, with a little T.V. monitor. And it's totally different from a jazz

MR: What are you seeing on the monitor in that situation?

GC: The stage.

MR: Oh the stage.

GC: Because I had to catch certain things. I could see the conductor.

MR: Things have changed some. Some of the shows to come to this area, first of all of course the pit bands are shrinking in size, it's just too bad, but on occasion they've even had some of the stuff pre-recorded, so that the whole thing is turned around, where the conductor is conducting to a pre-recorded track, and the singers are singing it.

GC: The difference with that and if I may, is the lack of energy. If you see a show with a live band there, there's an energy that's communicated, not only to the audience but to the dancers, the actors. And it just comes out. If there's a pre-recorded tape, I think there's a lack of energy, and the overall performance is not that of having live musicians there. Somewhat like having a D.J. at a wedding.

MR: Good point. Very prevalent around here unfortunately. So did you continue your education in a more formal setting?

GC: Yes I did. I went to a very formal school that we'll just omit the name, and started to study there, and was not happy at all with the teaching staff and the direction I was going. Of course I had been out and playing, and I knew what I needed. I just wasn't at their beck and call. I knew what I needed, and they weren't giving it to me. So I pulled out of the school and started asking successful drummers and musicians about a good communicator. Not only a good player, but someone that could communicate that knowledge. And I found a gentlemen, Art Perretta, in Hartford, who was teaching at the Hartford Conservatory. And I studied with him for about three years. And he gave me classical training, taught me how to read, a wonderful teacher, and again a big influence, and a very mild mannered man, and also instilled some of that into me too, and how to interact with other musicians on and off the bandstand. And I think my worst lesson with him was I finished playing a book and he closed it, and he says, "Gregory, I can do no more for you." And it left such an impact because I had such respect for this man. He says, "You need to go on with another teacher." And I did.

MR: A bittersweet moment perhaps.

GC: It was. I gave him a hug and still keep in contact with him to this day, and he with me.

MR: The instructors at this school that you choose not to mention, do you think the problem was were the teachers there more academiacs — is that a word?

GC: Maybe, but I know what you mean. I have to say yes. Literally putting in time and not taking a personal side to teaching, really analyzing what the students need, and looking at the clock, your half hour's up, things of that nature. I just wasn't happy with that.

MR: So you moved on from that instructor. It was pretty apparent to you at this time that I'm going to make a living as a drummer.

GC: Yes. I moved on to Joe Morello at that time. And the impact was — although there had been a void of time because he had practice and everything, he was on the road quite a bit. And I went down to see him in Irvington, New Jersey. And I got frightened in a big way because there were some big names around me. He has like, if you will a "green" room, and he picks and chooses who he's going to take next. If you call up and ask Joe Morello for a lesson time, it's twelve o'clock for everybody. So at that time anyway, and we were all in this pool, and I was listening to some of these drummers warm up and it frightened me. There were some fantastic players there. And I was like half the speed of everyone. And—

MR: Dr. Morello's office.

GC: Right. Joe Sepchik had brought me down. Joe Sepchik was one of Joe Morello's students. And he came into the lesson with me, and he was Joe Morello's teacher and there was some small talk then I started to play. And Joe frightened me. He let me know exactly where I was on the totem pole, and I went for it. I went after it. I took the challenge and I worked very hard and really became a technique freak for a while, and wanted to get up to that level, and I did, but also Joe is a phenomenal teacher and he told me, "Time and space too, kid."

MR: Well I'm curious, that first time with him, and he said to you well play something. What do you play in a situation like that? Do you solo, do you play some time, or is it a combination of both?

GC: Well he had me play a little bit on the pad, and I played some rudiments for him, okay, yes I see, okay well let's try your reading. Well I had studied with a reading teacher and I read the things down cold. He says okay fine, your reading's fine, let's go over to the drumset. And I sat behind the drumset. Well let's hear your foot. And I can remember he had a certain pedal tension the way that he played, and I couldn't play anything and he went yuck. We need to work on that. So from now on I brought my own pedal to his lessons. He's a master teacher too. But like I say the only warning I would give anybody that would listen to this tape, be ready. Because he's not, he's a master, and it could frustrate you.

MR: When was your first — did you have a time, place or person that you felt was really a significant gig in this early, you were what in your late teens or early twenties? Was there something that came up at that time that, boy, this is really important?

GC: I think it's because I did respect my father and what he did. The phone would ring all the time and for someone just to call you up and hire you, and think enough of your craft to

she explained it to me, well these people are having weddings, concerts, music lessons, and they're calling for your dad. And that impressed me about it. And it impressed me how dedicated he was because he would get up every morning and practice for a couple of hours. And he knew tunes, he knew jazz tunes, he would work at them, practice for hours, and did until the day he passed on.

MR: And so he was the kind of musician that, much like yourself, could function in a lot of different settings. As you mentioned, versatility.

GC: He could, yes. He wasn't a show player, and that's probably why he got me in that situation. He says just listen, you can push it through. But I couldn't. You can't. And sooner or later I think everybody that tries it, I've seen it with students come back to me, who have gotten into a situation where they think they can do a show and the conductor has them for lunch. And it doesn't work, and they come back, and they say please, put on the shine, what can I do? You know he couldn't read because he was legally blind.

MR: So when did the first opportunity come up for you, that a pretty big name called you to work?

GC: I got a job in the Catskills one summer. And all the big names came through. All the acts came through, from Milton Berle to Joan Rivers, everybody came through from New York. Some of them I got to play, some I didn't because they carried their own drummers, but most of them I did. And it was kind of frightening coming from Springfield, Mass. but again someone knew me, a bass player that had heard me and recommended me for the job. And it was an exciting summer.

MR: Did you get rehearsal time with these different people.

GC: Yes.

MR: In the afternoon or something, is that how that worked?

GC: Most of these acts come in from East Cupcake, they're tired, they're irritable, they're hungry, and they want these rehearsals kept short, and so doesn't the owner and the conductor, because they're paying us. So it's imperative that you can just play the opener, play the ending of the tune, turn the page and go on. They don't want to practice.

MR: They don't want to go through the whole tune.

GC: No. It's just opening — they want to hear if you can play, if you can do it, and it's really important right off that you get their confidence. And if you can fine. If you can't you just, it draws — I've been through shows that have drawn every bit of my energy and every bit of my talent just to get through.

MR: Did you ever have any train wrecks along the way, that maybe necessarily weren't your fault, but something happened?

GC: I can remember breaking a drum head. I played for Milton Berle, who had a lot of music,

shot right at the beginning. And we practiced this rim shot during rehearsal. So I thought, boy it he going to get a rim shot, in a packed showroom. And I came from above my head with the butt of the stick, and came down on that drum head, and there was no saving it. I split the head completely across, which — no sound at all. And the only method I could think to get through the show was I turned the drum over and played on the bottom head, and I broke that too, because the bottom head is significantly thinner than the top. So how'd I get around that? Well I slid over my floor tom and did that. It didn't have a great sound but I got through the show. Yeah that was an interesting show.

MR: And the drummer, for comedians, you're probably expected to do all the little kedda-boom-crash.

GC: You have to be a mind reader. You almost have to second guess them. I think it's probably something that any show drummer has to be is you have to be ahead. You have to be reading ahead, and thinking ahead what will happen. And if someone's in trouble it's almost like you have to save the show.

MR: Man you really have to be on the top of your game and alert for those things.

GC: You try and be. Things happen that are just beyond your control. I can remember doing a Frank Gorshin show, an impersonator, in Nassau. And the piano player was a jazz player but not really versed in playing shows. And when we did the rehearsal everything was okay. But he didn't put the music back in order. And Frank does like a country/western impersonation, an Elliot Ness, and he reversed those two charts. So when he came out with the hat and did the Elliot Ness thing, he played "Turkey in the Straw." And it didn't go over well at all with Frank and he certainly let the band know afterwards. Although the audience thought it was funny. And later I found out that he actually instituted that into his show.

MR: That's opportunistic of him. If it gets a laugh, it must be good, right?

GC: Yeah. It did, so.

MR: That's funny. Great. Going from shows to jazz, if you had your choice, which would you want to do?

GC: No doubt about it, I love playing jazz. I love feeling the musicians around me, the spontaneity, the call and response. It's no doubt about it, that jazz is my favorite.

MR: Is there a series of jazz musicians, ensembles or engagements that you really think back fondly of?

GC: I had an opportunity once, there used to be a jazz club in Hartford, Tobacco Valley, and they had a summer series. And at one point I became the house drummer. And Charlie Ventura came through, a great jazz saxophone player, Billy Butterfield came through, phenomenal, and I got to play with these people and learn from them. And they were of

section, but they were happy, most of the time they were happy. So I look back fondly on that. And certainly playing with some of the big bands, I performed with the Artie Shaw Band and Dick Johnson, another master. And each time I play with these people there's something that I learn. The learning process is continuing, it's wonderful.

MR: We haven't talked too much about the dancing aspect. Those engagements that you mentioned, Charlie Ventura, were they dance places or were they more listening rooms?

GC: They were strictly concert rooms.

MR: Okay. But when you go to do the big band thing, does that change at all? I mean I guess my question is — if there is one here — is in playing for dancers, how does this determine tempos and that kind of thing?

GC: When I play for dancers, I simplify. That's what I do. And all of the big bands that I've performed with have two books. There's a concert book and there's a dance book. And yes the Artie Shaw Big Band has a dance book and I simplify. It's like I give them backbeat and time. I concentrate on the time, rather than syncopation, as I do in the other book, the concert book. I lay it down and it keeps me working. So when I play for dancers it's time.

MR: To get drum specific, when you say you lay it down, what — do you play more of something on your set, less or something on your set, I mean can you define "laying it down" for me?

GC: Well when I play jazz for instance my bass drum becomes a separate voice. There's nothing definite that I play, it becomes a separate voice. Everything becomes a separate voice, as in bebop. But with swing music, or dance music, I will keep an ostinato four on the bass drum. And two and four on the hi-hat. And a swing rhythm is two and four on the snare drum, to simplify mostly. It's laying, it's locking in the time. Therefore, just leaving a nice pillow for the other musicians to play on. If they feel confident in the time, the band will sound good, and they'll be able to create. There'll be a like what we call "in the pocket" feel, if the musicians feel comfortable.

MR: That was a good answer. I like that.

GC: Thank you.

MR: Because it's easy to say you've got to be in the pocket, or any other cliché, but exactly what that means sometimes can change from one situation to another I guess.

GC: It does. Each band has a special need. And it's my job to find out as soon as I can, either from knowing who's on it, just by knowing the personalities, or listening to them play, within the first four bars I know what I have to work with in the rhythm section and what I have to adjust to.

MR: Do you get to play in odd time signatures at all?

GC: Not enough. I love to do it. I love to do it. When I perform a clinic, I address the odd time issue as much as I can. They're not danceable.

MR: No. Not unless your legs are not the same length or something. Tell me about playing on the — doing the cruise work. I've often wondered what exactly that is like.

GC: Well it can — if you go out with an individual, I went out with Dom DeLuise once, an excellent comedian with eight pounds of music by the way, he sings, he dances, which there's a side of him you don't see. He sings opera and you have to know how to play these things. And going on with a celebrity is different than being the house drummer shall we say. We got Class A rooms, and we just played the show, which left plenty of time to go ashore and plenty of time to eat, and those cruises with him were very memorable and relaxing. We had great food, great people always great people on the band, and a wonderful, excellent personality, fun. Never stopped laughing. Practical joker. Those are fun. Being the house drummer is different nowadays because you have to wear a uniform, you have to help with shuffleboard during the day now, and you have what they call crew quarters, which are below the water line, and are not the most comfortable. And pay is not that great because they like to go after players and say well here is a paid vacation. Here's pocket money and you're going to see the world.

MR: Below the water line though.

GC: Yeah, students will come to me and say hey I got a call for a cruise. And I say wait a minute, let's talk about this. And really being on a cruise for six months destroys any network that you've built, because you're out of the music business, you're out of contact.

MR: You can't even take like phone calls for work six months from then.

GC: Nope.

MR: It's something to think about.

GC: It destroys a network. Shore cruises are fine, two weeks or something like that are fine, and going out with a celebrity is the best because you get the excellent treatment, which you deserve.

MR: They make you help with shuffleboard now, huh? Well can you tell me about, you said the Benny Goodman Big Band is coming up and I know you've done some of that in the past.

GC: Yeah I was quite flattered. I can remember sitting in the Artie Shaw Band for the first time and opening the book and see that signature of Buddy Rich in there, and it hit me in a big way, that I had forgotten that he had sat in that chair. And the responsibility was, when Dick Johnson would announce that Buddy Rich was with the band and he used to solo, he used to change the tunes, "Lady Be Good," there was a responsibility there I felt,

myself to death because I had a responsibility there. And with the Benny Goodman Band of course one of my favorite drummers, Gene Krupa was with that band, and I also feel a responsibility to that. I can remember playing, we did a sextet job, a small band with vibes and someone came up to me and they said, "Gene, you look great." Because my initials are GC and they just assumed it was Gene Krupa. And, "You're playing better than ever." Well I didn't think and I responded, "Well thank you very much but Gene has passed on." And the person was devastated. They were devastated over this. And the leader of the band pulled me over and he said, "Never, ever — you're whoever they want you to be. They come and they're living a dream, and don't ever say anybody passed on." So there's a responsibility there.

MR: Yeah. That's significant, that they're living a dream that this music made such an impression on them in their younger years. It's important that they hear it like they remember it I guess.

GC: Yes. I say to some of the musicians that take these jobs, don't do that. If you're playing swing music, you're not playing bebop. I mean there's a difference there and you have a responsibility. And as a result they go through a lot of musicians in these bands. You have to know the style. So if you get a call, do your homework.

MR: Good advice. Something that can you verbalize this — well we talked about this, trying to verbalize that to students, that a gig is perhaps not for you to show all your chops off. Maybe you'll get your moment at some point to do that, but—

GC: It's much better to be asked to play louder than softer. It's much better to be asked to play a little more than a little less. And these are tools that I've used throughout my career, and invaluable, and I convey that to my students. You know you'll get your chance, don't ask for a drum solo, let them ask you, it's much more credible that way, particularly if you can really play one.

MR: I think we'll put those last few sentences in capitals when we do the transcript here. That's really good advice.

GC: Thank you.

MR: Darius Brubeck? You played with him and everywhere from there to the Coasters.

GC: Yes. Like I say I am versatile and jazz is my music but I bring something from all these experiences into my playing. I was doing a big band show with what I'll call a vintage big band, it was playing a concert. And I looked to my left and there was Darius Brubeck playing trombone. And an excellent musician. And again he was coming out of his jazz context into the vintage music style to add something to his jazz repertoire. And an excellent musician, and I envy people that can jump from trombone and play bass as well. It's having a father like Dave Brubeck, it's tough. Because you're out there and

people automatically expect you to be great. And it's something you have to deal with when your spouse is a musician.

MR: His other son is quite a good drummer.

GC: Danny, yeah, excellent. They're all fine musicians and something that I found out — that when Paul Desmond passed away he left his saxophone to the Brubeck son who did not choose to play music, in hopes that someday he would pick up the saxophone, which I thought was very interesting.

MR: Now let's see you've mentioned Buddy Rich and Gene Krupa and Joe Morello. Who is the player that you like to listen to who you would consider, oh let's say the most modern?

GC: I've heard maybe Gene Krupa in his recordings come up with something what I would consider modern. My next door neighbor plays drums, and he's played some things that I will borrow shall we say. Everybody has something to offer. I really don't have any favorites. I listen to everybody and help everybody I can. It's just ongoing, that's the way I think it should be, everybody helping and I have no favorites. One of my students, who might take his third lesson, "Well I've been practicing this, what do you think?" And it will just astound me, what a great lick. I can use this. So my students are my favorite drummers. My washing machine last week broke, the bearings went and it had this great sound with this blanket in it. And I wrote it down before I unplugged it because it turned out something, I said I can apply that. So I listen to everything, not only drummers but sounds.

MR: Wow. Was the washing machine in four?

GC: No actually I think it was nine-eight but you know, it's something that I can use, and I got it down and I'll work on it, and I'll throw it into a four bar lick somewhere along the line.

MR: That's great. It's neat to hear. People like Tony Williams, those kind of drummers, do you enjoy them also?

GC: Yes, a master, definitely. Taught me how to use the hi-hat listening to him, and he played the hi-hat on all four, and I do that sometimes — sometimes too, I'll wake up the bass player, or to calm them down, because that'll draw, it draws attention without slamming down a bass drum, so I would use that technique sometimes with a piano player. So I use a jazz technique in a big band, so I pull from him, definitely a master, a powerful, powerful drummer. So sad that he left us so early.

MR: What do you think of the state of jazz today?

GC: I think that CDs — LPs being reissued on CDs, I definitely think there's a resurgence. At colleges, many big bands, big interest in jazz. I play a club and I look out there and I see younger players. Younger players will talk to the jazz masters, drive three, four hundred

miles to hear somebody, their idol, follow them around, study with them. I think there's a big surgence. It's apple pie, jazz is a Americana.

MR: Good statement. It's home grown. Have you experienced any kind of, or witnessed any racial scene in jazz that you find significant?

GC: I have a friend who's a drummer. He happens to be a person of color, and I don't even like to say that to be honest with you because I look at people as people and I've never met a man I don't like, Will Rogers. It's however they act and treat me that will judge that in the end. But I've been in situations where I've gone to clubs that were predominantly black and I just don't have that attitude so they don't give me that attitude. My friend is a person of color and he's like one of my best friends. And we share jobs, anxieties, I just look — there's four people up on the bandstand and that's how I look at it. And I've never been in a situation with musicians — maybe at first there might be some apprehension on their part, but as soon as they hear me play it dissolves and we have a great gig.

MR: From what I've been able to observe it seems like there's a healthy group of fairly young musicians who are keeping the let's say mainstream tradition alive, kind of a little resurgence with Scott Hamilton there, but it doesn't seem like there's as many young black musicians who are embracing that style, that they seem to be devoted more towards really kind of modern.

GC: Well we could talk about that. I think that what you're saying is partially true about them keeping the roots of bebop alive, but I hear experimentation from some younger players, I mean get into that. Maybe what they're coming up with isn't commercially viable or marketable and so we don't really hear it. But as far as experimentation going on, certainly. But whether we can get record producers to get it out there is a big problem, and we may not be hearing some of the next steps to jazz or to modern music to fusion because simply I don't think the record companies want to take a chance. They want the sure thing. They want the already-established name to come out with the CD where they can project record, CD sales. So I think the experimentation is going on. I hear it with college groups, writers, but it's not getting out there and I think it's really something that needs to be addressed.

MR: What's your feeling when you listen to let's say light jazz, contemporary jazz, that obviously have a little box providing all the drums?

GC: As far as what I call synthetic instruments, I think the height is passed. I really do. I think in studios, I get calls to do jingles because they want the human factor. They don't want the sterile time or the sound, they want the real person. And I think like electronic drums, I think the time for that is passed. We tried it, it came out, and while it was a nice toy, but

a keyboard player in a lounge that has drums programmed into it, I think is almost circus-like now to the public. They want to hear, they want to see the real players.

MR: I hope you're right.

GC: I think I am.

MR: What's in the near future for you? I know you mentioned you're going to be going to Europe with a group from U Mass.

GC: Yes I'm going out with Trade Winds, and some marvelous players that I'm excited about, and Fred Tillis on saxophone, and a marvelous upcoming bass player that I have been playing with, Genevieve Rose, who is looking forward to that, and I'm doing a cruise to Hawaii with the Benny Goodman big band, it's a jazz cruise, and there'll be several other groups on there and we'll trade off and I'm excited about that. It's a challenge to sit in Mr. Krupa's chair. I'm boning up for it.

MR: Who directs that group now?

GC: The leader is Everett Longstreth, and it's a Boston based band, as is the Artie Shaw band. I think Dick Johnson might be doing the clarinet work on that.

MR: Are those bands the property of the Goodman estate? Or how do they work that?

GC: Definitely the property of the estates. Like the Gene Krupa Big Band, Mrs. Krupa is still alive and if you use that name you have to pay up, which she's entitled to. I think it's justified.

MR: And they have the same arrangements, a lot of the same arrangements that they play?

GC: Yeah, which I think should be in a museum somewhere, but when I opened up the Artie Shaw book, it's the original "Begin the Beguine."

MR: No kidding, the original music.

GC: And the original "Nightmare" is on the road, which really shouldn't be.

MR: Yeah, because sooner or later it's going to get dumped in the water getting loaded on the boat or something.

GC: Exactly. And this stuff should be copied, but that costs money and a lot of these bands are operating on a shoestring and it's a tragedy. Someone will have to call up the estate and say the rental for the bus is due and we haven't made it yet this month. So it's a tragedy. This is again, Americana, it should be available for everybody to hear, and it would be nice if they had some government support.

MR: Do you ever look back in time, speaking of Americana, if you could go back in a time machine, would there be an era that you would prefer or be interested in living in?

GC: There is a specific concert that I would love to attend, but to go back to the big band era, like during World War II, I think when they were at their height I think. I would love to go back and spend a couple of years and listen, and that would be great to experience

concert. But there's definitely one concert, in 1963 there was a concert, in November, that the Dave Brubeck Quartet performed. And it was a legendary concert. And it is out on a double CD right now, where everybody was just at their prime and swinging and the group had never really reached heights like that before and it was recorded. And probably the most phenomenal drum solo ever performed was done at that concert, and I would like to have observed that.

MR: Was that at a college in the midwest or something?

GC: It was at Carnegie Hall. At the time the newspapers were on strike and they didn't think there was going to be anyone there. It was sold out. And when they walked out there, just the sound of the hall and the sold out audience, everybody played phenomenal. Joe Morello had the flu, and how he ever pulled off this, what I only can say as far as I'm concerned, the greatest drum solo ever played, I would have liked to have been there for that.

MR: Much like an athlete, just reach down and pulled out that, whatever Muhammad Ali had.

GC: And he is, he's up there with those people. It was a phenomenal concert. I would have liked to have been there. I think every musician would have a concert they're after.

MR: Well I heard them, in oh gosh it must have been probably around '65 I think. Would that make sense? They were together then right? At the Eastman School of Music. And that was a good one. But I just remember how unassuming Desmond especially. You know I mean he looked like a banker or something. But he had that sense of, if you could sit down and write out a perfect solo, he already played it.

GC: Yeah definitely a lyricist, a wonderful, wonderful player. Something about Paul Desmond to this day you can hear a saxophone and you know right away. Something that you don't hear from the younger players today. Everybody is tending to sound the same. When you hear Phil Woods you know it's Phil Woods. Paul Desmond, you know it's him. Joe Morello you know it's him. Tony. Drummers tend, and other musicians too tend to want to sound all alike. You know it's probably the fault of sound men, they have one sound, there's one drum sound, there's one saxophone sound, but it shouldn't be that way. Everybody should strive for their own sound and their own style. And that's something that I try and talk to my students about, don't sound like me, please. Don't buy Buddy Rich videos and try and sound exactly like him. You know, imitate, assimilate, innovate.

MR: Good words. In fact you anticipated my wrap up question here, was if you had words of advice for upcoming students, I think you did but would you add anything to that?

GC: I think you have to live the music. I think if you want to be a professional musician you have to live it. You have to spend twenty-four hours a day practicing, listening, performing, play all you can. And I think one of the sure ingredients to failure is to try to

ears and want to learn. But have your own style. And everybody is not going to like the way you play, and don't be discouraged about it. Joe Morello passed that along to me. If you are satisfying sixty percent of the people, you're doing great. There's people that just aren't going to like you for the clothes you wear, the color of your set, don't let it bother you, and don't ever, ever, ever give up.

MR: Well excellent sentiments. And I want to thank you for joining us today. It's been a great pleasure.

GC: Thank you for having me.

MR: And good luck with your upcoming cruise.

GC: Thank you very much.

MR: If I was on it I would not expect to see the band members doing any shuffleboard.

GC: There's tickets available by the way.

MR: Oh yeah? It sounds like a nice place to be, and I hope you see some nice things in Europe.

GC: I'm looking forward to it.

MR: And I hope you get to play in an odd time signature sometime soon.

GC: Thank you very much.

MR: All right.

GC: A pleasure.

MR: Thanks a lot.